

Bridge, Lift & Production Tricks

The bridge: something different

By the bridge, the listener has heard the verse and chorus twice. Give them something new, then send them back to the chorus fresh.

Pick **two or three** kinds of contrast:

- ☐ **New chords** — start on a chord the song hasn't started on (IV or vi is common)
- ☐ **New melody shape** — lower and wordier, or higher and longer, than the chorus
- ☐ **New lyric angle** — a twist, a realization, the other side of the story
- ☐ **New energy** — drop way down, or build way up

End the bridge on V (G in C, D in G). It pulls strongly back to the chorus.

Bridge chord ideas (key of C):

- F – G – Am – Am (IV – V – vi – vi)
- Am – F – C – G (vi – IV – I – V)
- F – Fm – C – G (borrowed iv)

What hasn't my song said yet? _____

The lift: make the last chorus the biggest

- ☐ **Key change** — move the final chorus up 1 or 2 semitones
- ☐ **New layer** — harmony vocals, octave-up melody, a riff, bigger drums
- ☐ **Drop and return** — first half of the chorus is just vocal + one instrument, then everything comes back
- ☐ **Ad-libs** — the singer improvises around the melody

No bridge? A **double final chorus** with a lift works too.

Production tricks

Arrangement is subtraction. Something should change every 4 or 8 bars.

Pick **at least three**:

- ☐ **Drop-out** — mute everything except the vocal (or drums) for 1–2 bars, then bring it back
 - ☐ **Build / riser** — snare roll, rising synth, or reverse cymbal before a chorus. Search Apple Loops for "riser," "sweep," or "uplifter"
 - ☐ **Filter sweep** — chords sound muffled, then open up
 - ☐ **Volume automation** — a pad fades in over the pre-chorus; the chorus gets a little louder
 - ☐ **Ear candy** — a tiny one-time sound: a "hey," a reversed note, a sound effect
 - ☐ **Sampling** — record a household sound in GarageBand's Sampler and play it as an instrument
 - ☐ **Octave double** — play the hook or riff an octave higher on a new sound in the chorus
 - ☐ **Air pocket** — one beat of silence right before the chorus
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Transitions

At every section change, give a signal:

- A drum fill
 - A crash cymbal on beat 1 of the new section
 - A riser
 - A drop-out
 - A one-beat stop
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Reference check

Play your song, then a song you admire. Compare:

- Is my vocal as clear?
- Is my chorus as big?
- Does something change as often?

One thing I'll fix: _____